

SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Political Parties - Learner-v2 Refreshed

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing



Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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Political Parties - Solved Practice Workbook

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

Original MCQs 1-36 - Broad Coverage

OM1. Which statement most accurately describes constitutional status of parties?

- A. The original Constitution did not create a comprehensive party code; later provisions regulate specific fields.
- B. Political parties are wholly unregulated by law.
- C. Article 324 itself registers political parties.
- D. The Tenth Schedule regulates every aspect of party organisation.

Answer: A

Explanation: Party law is segmented across the Constitution, statutes and the Symbols Order. The other options collapse distinct legal sources, institutions or consequences and therefore fail the close-option test.

OM2. Which statement most accurately describes Section 29A?

- A. Section 29A grants national-party recognition.
- B. Section 29A of the RPA 1951 provides the statutory registration route and allegiance declaration.
- C. Section 29A makes every registered party a public authority.
- D. Section 29A creates the anti-defection whip.

Answer: B

Explanation: Registration is distinct from recognition, defection and RTI status. The other options collapse distinct legal sources, institutions or consequences and therefore fail the close-option test.

OM3. Which statement most accurately describes recognition?

- A. Recognition follows Article 324 alone without an Order.
- B. Every registered party has a reserved symbol.
- C. National and State recognition follows dated criteria in the Election Symbols Order, not an immutable constitutional list.
- D. Recognition never changes after first grant.

Answer: C

Explanation: Criteria and lists must be rechecked against ECI orders. The other options collapse distinct legal sources, institutions or consequences and therefore fail the close-option test.

OM4. Which statement most accurately describes party functions?

- A. Parties only nominate candidates.
- B. Interest aggregation belongs only to pressure groups.
- C. Opposition is external to the party system.
- D. Parties aggregate interests, recruit leaders, form governments, organise opposition and enable electoral accountability.

Answer: D

Explanation: The democratic role extends across representation, government and accountability. The other options collapse distinct legal sources, institutions or consequences and therefore fail the close-option test.

OM5. Which statement most accurately describes internal democracy?

- A. India lacks a comprehensive statutory internal-democracy code despite registration and disclosure requirements.
- B. The ECI conducts all internal party elections.
- C. The Constitution prescribes candidate-selection primaries.

- D. Dynastic succession is itself a statutory disqualification.

Answer: A

Explanation: Autonomy and minimum democratic safeguards must be balanced. The other options collapse distinct legal sources, institutions or consequences and therefore fail the close-option test.

OM6. Which statement most accurately describes party finance?

- A. The judgment constitutionalised anonymous bonds.
- B. The 2024 electoral-bonds judgment invalidated the scheme and enabling anonymity changes on right-to-information grounds.
- C. The judgment prohibited every corporate donation.
- D. The judgment created full State funding of elections.

Answer: B

Explanation: One instrument was struck down; the wider finance framework still needs statutory analysis. The other options collapse distinct legal sources, institutions or consequences and therefore fail the close-option test.

OM7. Which statement most accurately describes candidate disclosure?

- A. Disclosure arises only after conviction.
- B. Candidate education is constitutionally irrelevant and cannot be disclosed.
- C. ADR (2002) and PUCL (2003) ground candidate-affidavit disclosure in the voter's right to know.
- D. The ECI may cancel an election solely for any pending case.

Answer: C

Explanation: Disclosure and disqualification are different mechanisms. The other options collapse distinct legal sources, institutions or consequences and therefore fail the close-option test.

OM8. Which statement most accurately describes criminalisation?

- A. Every chargesheet causes automatic disqualification.
- B. Disclosure alone equals acquittal.
- C. Political parties cannot nominate a person with pending cases.
- D. Lily Thomas (2013) removed the sitting-member protection in RPA Section 8(4), but disqualification still depends on conviction.

Answer: D

Explanation: The core gap is the delay between accusation, trial and conviction. The other options collapse distinct legal sources, institutions or consequences and therefore fail the close-option test.

OM9. Which statement most accurately describes NOTA?

- A. NOTA protects a negative voting choice but does not automatically cancel the election or require re-poll.
- B. NOTA votes are transferred to the runner-up.
- C. NOTA converts India to recall elections.
- D. NOTA disqualifies all listed candidates.

Answer: A

Explanation: PUCL (2013) concerns secrecy and choice, not automatic rejection of the field. The other options collapse distinct legal sources, institutions or consequences and therefore fail the close-option test.

OM10. Which statement most accurately describes anti-defection interface?

- A. A party whip can criminally punish a voter.
- B. The Tenth Schedule disciplines legislators; it is not a general code for party membership or finance.
- C. Every internal party dispute is decided by the Speaker.
- D. The Symbols Order and Tenth Schedule are the same proceeding.

Answer: B

Explanation: Party, legislature-party, symbol and defection questions remain distinct. The other options collapse distinct legal sources, institutions or consequences and therefore fail the close-option test.

OM11. Which statement most accurately describes deregistration?

- A. The ECI has an unlimited policy power to deregister inactive parties.
- B. Recognition withdrawal and registration cancellation are identical.
- C. Indian National Congress v. Institute of Social Welfare (2002) limits ECI cancellation to narrow grounds such as fraud or loss of foundational allegiance.
- D. The Supreme Court barred cancellation even for fraud.

Answer: C

Explanation: Registration power does not imply a general merits-based deregistration power. The other options collapse distinct legal sources, institutions or consequences and therefore fail the close-option test.

OM12. Which statement most accurately describes regional parties and coalitions?

- A. Regional parties are constitutionally confined to State elections.
- B. Coalitions are unconstitutional when no party has a majority.
- C. National parties always favour autonomy.
- D. Regional parties can deepen federal representation while also increasing bargaining and coordination costs.

Answer: D

Explanation: Effects depend on incentives, alliances and institutional context. The other options collapse distinct legal sources, institutions or consequences and therefore fail the close-option test.

OM13. Which is the safest UPSC distinction concerning constitutional status of parties?

- A. The original Constitution did not create a comprehensive party code; later provisions regulate specific fields.
- B. Political parties are wholly unregulated by law.
- C. Article 324 itself registers political parties.
- D. The Tenth Schedule regulates every aspect of party organisation.

Answer: A

Explanation: Party law is segmented across the Constitution, statutes and the Symbols Order. The other options collapse distinct legal sources, institutions or consequences and therefore fail the close-option test.

OM14. Which is the safest UPSC distinction concerning Section 29A?

- A. Section 29A grants national-party recognition.
- B. Section 29A of the RPA 1951 provides the statutory registration route and allegiance declaration.
- C. Section 29A creates the anti-defection whip.
- D. Section 29A makes every registered party a public authority.

Answer: B

Explanation: Registration is distinct from recognition, defection and RTI status. The other options collapse distinct legal sources, institutions or consequences and therefore fail the close-option test.

OM15. Which is the safest UPSC distinction concerning recognition?

- A. Recognition follows Article 324 alone without an Order.
- B. Every registered party has a reserved symbol.
- C. National and State recognition follows dated criteria in the Election Symbols Order, not an immutable constitutional list.
- D. Recognition never changes after first grant.

Answer: C

Explanation: Criteria and lists must be rechecked against ECI orders. The other options collapse distinct legal sources, institutions or consequences and therefore fail the close-option test.

OM16. Which is the safest UPSC distinction concerning party functions?

- A. Parties only nominate candidates.
- B. Opposition is external to the party system.
- C. Interest aggregation belongs only to pressure groups.
- D. Parties aggregate interests, recruit leaders, form governments, organise opposition and enable electoral accountability.

Answer: D

Explanation: The democratic role extends across representation, government and accountability. The other options collapse distinct legal sources, institutions or consequences and therefore fail the close-option test.

OM17. Which is the safest UPSC distinction concerning internal democracy?

- A. India lacks a comprehensive statutory internal-democracy code despite registration and disclosure requirements.
- B. The Constitution prescribes candidate-selection primaries.
- C. The ECI conducts all internal party elections.
- D. Dynastic succession is itself a statutory disqualification.

Answer: A

Explanation: Autonomy and minimum democratic safeguards must be balanced. The other options collapse distinct legal sources, institutions or consequences and therefore fail the close-option test.

OM18. Which is the safest UPSC distinction concerning party finance?

- A. The judgment constitutionalised anonymous bonds.
- B. The 2024 electoral-bonds judgment invalidated the scheme and enabling anonymity changes on right-to-information grounds.
- C. The judgment created full State funding of elections.
- D. The judgment prohibited every corporate donation.

Answer: B

Explanation: One instrument was struck down; the wider finance framework still needs statutory analysis. The other options collapse distinct legal sources, institutions or consequences and therefore fail the close-option test.

OM19. Which is the safest UPSC distinction concerning candidate disclosure?

- A. Disclosure arises only after conviction.
- B. The ECI may cancel an election solely for any pending case.
- C. ADR (2002) and PUCL (2003) ground candidate-affidavit disclosure in the voter's right to know.
- D. Candidate education is constitutionally irrelevant and cannot be disclosed.

Answer: C

Explanation: Disclosure and disqualification are different mechanisms. The other options collapse distinct legal sources, institutions or consequences and therefore fail the close-option test.

OM20. Which is the safest UPSC distinction concerning criminalisation?

- A. Every chargesheet causes automatic disqualification.
- B. Political parties cannot nominate a person with pending cases.
- C. Disclosure alone equals acquittal.
- D. Lily Thomas (2013) removed the sitting-member protection in RPA Section 8(4), but disqualification still depends on conviction.

Answer: D

Explanation: The core gap is the delay between accusation, trial and conviction. The other options collapse distinct legal sources, institutions or consequences and therefore fail the close-option test.

OM21. Which is the safest UPSC distinction concerning NOTA?

- A. NOTA protects a negative voting choice but does not automatically cancel the election or require re-poll.
- B. NOTA converts India to recall elections.
- C. NOTA votes are transferred to the runner-up.
- D. NOTA disqualifies all listed candidates.

Answer: A

Explanation: PUCL (2013) concerns secrecy and choice, not automatic rejection of the field. The other options collapse distinct legal sources, institutions or consequences and therefore fail the close-option test.

OM22. Which is the safest UPSC distinction concerning anti-defection interface?

- A. A party whip can criminally punish a voter.
- B. The Tenth Schedule disciplines legislators; it is not a general code for party membership or finance.
- C. Every internal party dispute is decided by the Speaker.
- D. The Symbols Order and Tenth Schedule are the same proceeding.

Answer: B

Explanation: Party, legislature-party, symbol and defection questions remain distinct. The other options collapse distinct legal sources, institutions or consequences and therefore fail the close-option test.

OM23. Which is the safest UPSC distinction concerning deregistration?

- A. The ECI has an unlimited policy power to deregister inactive parties.
- B. Recognition withdrawal and registration cancellation are identical.
- C. Indian National Congress v. Institute of Social Welfare (2002) limits ECI cancellation to narrow grounds such as fraud or loss of foundational allegiance.
- D. The Supreme Court barred cancellation even for fraud.

Answer: C

Explanation: Registration power does not imply a general merits-based deregistration power. The other options collapse distinct legal sources, institutions or consequences and therefore fail the close-option test.

OM24. Which is the safest UPSC distinction concerning regional parties and coalitions?

- A. Regional parties are constitutionally confined to State elections.
- B. National parties always favour autonomy.
- C. Coalitions are unconstitutional when no party has a majority.
- D. Regional parties can deepen federal representation while also increasing bargaining and coordination costs.

Answer: D

Explanation: Effects depend on incentives, alliances and institutional context. The other options collapse distinct legal sources, institutions or consequences and therefore fail the close-option test.

OM25. A candidate makes a close-option error about constitutional status of parties. Which correction is most accurate?

- A. The original Constitution did not create a comprehensive party code; later provisions regulate specific fields.
- B. Political parties are wholly unregulated by law.
- C. Article 324 itself registers political parties.
- D. The Tenth Schedule regulates every aspect of party organisation.

Answer: A

Explanation: Party law is segmented across the Constitution, statutes and the Symbols Order. The other options collapse distinct legal sources, institutions or consequences and therefore fail the close-option test.

OM26. A candidate makes a close-option error about Section 29A. Which correction is most accurate?

- A. Section 29A makes every registered party a public authority.

- B. Section 29A of the RPA 1951 provides the statutory registration route and allegiance declaration.
- C. Section 29A creates the anti-defection whip.
- D. Section 29A grants national-party recognition.

Answer: B

Explanation: Registration is distinct from recognition, defection and RTI status. The other options collapse distinct legal sources, institutions or consequences and therefore fail the close-option test.

OM27. A candidate makes a close-option error about recognition. Which correction is most accurate?

- A. Recognition follows Article 324 alone without an Order.
- B. Recognition never changes after first grant.
- C. National and State recognition follows dated criteria in the Election Symbols Order, not an immutable constitutional list.
- D. Every registered party has a reserved symbol.

Answer: C

Explanation: Criteria and lists must be rechecked against ECI orders. The other options collapse distinct legal sources, institutions or consequences and therefore fail the close-option test.

OM28. A candidate makes a close-option error about party functions. Which correction is most accurate?

- A. Parties only nominate candidates.
- B. Opposition is external to the party system.
- C. Interest aggregation belongs only to pressure groups.
- D. Parties aggregate interests, recruit leaders, form governments, organise opposition and enable electoral accountability.

Answer: D

Explanation: The democratic role extends across representation, government and accountability. The other options collapse distinct legal sources, institutions or consequences and therefore fail the close-option test.

OM29. A candidate makes a close-option error about internal democracy. Which correction is most accurate?

- A. India lacks a comprehensive statutory internal-democracy code despite registration and disclosure requirements.
- B. The ECI conducts all internal party elections.
- C. The Constitution prescribes candidate-selection primaries.
- D. Dynastic succession is itself a statutory disqualification.

Answer: A

Explanation: Autonomy and minimum democratic safeguards must be balanced. The other options collapse distinct legal sources, institutions or consequences and therefore fail the close-option test.

OM30. A candidate makes a close-option error about party finance. Which correction is most accurate?

- A. The judgment prohibited every corporate donation.
- B. The 2024 electoral-bonds judgment invalidated the scheme and enabling anonymity changes on right-to-information grounds.
- C. The judgment constitutionalised anonymous bonds.
- D. The judgment created full State funding of elections.

Answer: B

Explanation: One instrument was struck down; the wider finance framework still needs statutory analysis. The other options collapse distinct legal sources, institutions or consequences and therefore fail the close-option test.

OM31. A candidate makes a close-option error about candidate disclosure. Which correction is most accurate?

- A. Disclosure arises only after conviction.
- B. The ECI may cancel an election solely for any pending case.
- C. ADR (2002) and PUCL (2003) ground candidate-affidavit disclosure in the voter's right to know.
- D. Candidate education is constitutionally irrelevant and cannot be disclosed.

Answer: C

Explanation: Disclosure and disqualification are different mechanisms. The other options collapse distinct legal sources, institutions or consequences and therefore fail the close-option test.

OM32. A candidate makes a close-option error about criminalisation. Which correction is most accurate?

- A. Every chargesheet causes automatic disqualification.
- B. Disclosure alone equals acquittal.
- C. Political parties cannot nominate a person with pending cases.
- D. Lily Thomas (2013) removed the sitting-member protection in RPA Section 8(4), but disqualification still depends on conviction.

Answer: D

Explanation: The core gap is the delay between accusation, trial and conviction. The other options collapse distinct legal sources, institutions or consequences and therefore fail the close-option test.

OM33. A candidate makes a close-option error about NOTA. Which correction is most accurate?

- A. NOTA protects a negative voting choice but does not automatically cancel the election or require re-poll.
- B. NOTA disqualifies all listed candidates.
- C. NOTA votes are transferred to the runner-up.
- D. NOTA converts India to recall elections.

Answer: A

Explanation: PUCL (2013) concerns secrecy and choice, not automatic rejection of the field. The other options collapse distinct legal sources, institutions or consequences and therefore fail the close-option test.

OM34. A candidate makes a close-option error about anti-defection interface. Which correction is most accurate?

- A. The Symbols Order and Tenth Schedule are the same proceeding.
- B. The Tenth Schedule disciplines legislators; it is not a general code for party membership or finance.
- C. Every internal party dispute is decided by the Speaker.
- D. A party whip can criminally punish a voter.

Answer: B

Explanation: Party, legislature-party, symbol and defection questions remain distinct. The other options collapse distinct legal sources, institutions or consequences and therefore fail the close-option test.

OM35. A candidate makes a close-option error about deregistration. Which correction is most accurate?

- A. The ECI has an unlimited policy power to deregister inactive parties.
- B. Recognition withdrawal and registration cancellation are identical.
- C. Indian National Congress v. Institute of Social Welfare (2002) limits ECI cancellation to narrow grounds such as fraud or loss of foundational allegiance.
- D. The Supreme Court barred cancellation even for fraud.

Answer: C

Explanation: Registration power does not imply a general merits-based deregistration power. The other options collapse distinct legal sources, institutions or consequences and therefore fail the close-option test.

OM36. A candidate makes a close-option error about regional parties and coalitions. Which correction is most accurate?

- A. Regional parties are constitutionally confined to State elections.
- B. National parties always favour autonomy.
- C. Coalitions are unconstitutional when no party has a majority.
- D. Regional parties can deepen federal representation while also increasing bargaining and coordination costs.

Answer: D

Explanation: Effects depend on incentives, alliances and institutional context. The other options collapse distinct legal sources, institutions or consequences and therefore fail the close-option test.

Remedial MCQs 1-12 - Common Error Repair

RM1. Which statement best repairs a recurring error about constitutional status of parties?

- A. The original Constitution did not create a comprehensive party code; later provisions regulate specific fields.
- B. Article 324 itself registers political parties.
- C. The Tenth Schedule regulates every aspect of party organisation.
- D. Political parties are wholly unregulated by law.

Answer: A

Remedial explanation: Party law is segmented across the Constitution, statutes and the Symbols Order. Write the governing source, then the mechanism, and finally the limitation before choosing an option.

RM2. Which statement best repairs a recurring error about Section 29A?

- A. Section 29A creates the anti-defection whip.
- B. Section 29A of the RPA 1951 provides the statutory registration route and allegiance declaration.
- C. Section 29A makes every registered party a public authority.
- D. Section 29A grants national-party recognition.

Answer: B

Remedial explanation: Registration is distinct from recognition, defection and RTI status. Write the governing source, then the mechanism, and finally the limitation before choosing an option.

RM3. Which statement best repairs a recurring error about recognition?

- A. Every registered party has a reserved symbol.
- B. Recognition follows Article 324 alone without an Order.
- C. National and State recognition follows dated criteria in the Election Symbols Order, not an immutable constitutional list.
- D. Recognition never changes after first grant.

Answer: C

Remedial explanation: Criteria and lists must be rechecked against ECI orders. Write the governing source, then the mechanism, and finally the limitation before choosing an option.

RM4. Which statement best repairs a recurring error about party functions?

- A. Opposition is external to the party system.
- B. Parties only nominate candidates.
- C. Interest aggregation belongs only to pressure groups.
- D. Parties aggregate interests, recruit leaders, form governments, organise opposition and enable electoral accountability.

Answer: D

Remedial explanation: The democratic role extends across representation, government and accountability. Write the governing source, then the mechanism, and finally the limitation before choosing an option.

RM5. Which statement best repairs a recurring error about internal democracy?

- A. India lacks a comprehensive statutory internal-democracy code despite registration and disclosure requirements.
- B. Dynastic succession is itself a statutory disqualification.
- C. The Constitution prescribes candidate-selection primaries.
- D. The ECI conducts all internal party elections.

Answer: A

Remedial explanation: Autonomy and minimum democratic safeguards must be balanced. Write the governing source, then the mechanism, and finally the limitation before choosing an option.

RM6. Which statement best repairs a recurring error about party finance?

- A. The judgment prohibited every corporate donation.
- B. The 2024 electoral-bonds judgment invalidated the scheme and enabling anonymity changes on right-to-information grounds.
- C. The judgment created full State funding of elections.
- D. The judgment constitutionalised anonymous bonds.

Answer: B

Remedial explanation: One instrument was struck down; the wider finance framework still needs statutory analysis. Write the governing source, then the mechanism, and finally the limitation before choosing an option.

RM7. Which statement best repairs a recurring error about candidate disclosure?

- A. Disclosure arises only after conviction.
- B. Candidate education is constitutionally irrelevant and cannot be disclosed.
- C. ADR (2002) and PUCL (2003) ground candidate-affidavit disclosure in the voter's right to know.
- D. The ECI may cancel an election solely for any pending case.

Answer: C

Remedial explanation: Disclosure and disqualification are different mechanisms. Write the governing source, then the mechanism, and finally the limitation before choosing an option.

RM8. Which statement best repairs a recurring error about criminalisation?

- A. Every chargesheet causes automatic disqualification.
- B. Political parties cannot nominate a person with pending cases.
- C. Disclosure alone equals acquittal.
- D. Lily Thomas (2013) removed the sitting-member protection in RPA Section 8(4), but disqualification still depends on conviction.

Answer: D

Remedial explanation: The core gap is the delay between accusation, trial and conviction. Write the governing source, then the mechanism, and finally the limitation before choosing an option.

RM9. Which statement best repairs a recurring error about NOTA?

- A. NOTA protects a negative voting choice but does not automatically cancel the election or require re-poll.
- B. NOTA votes are transferred to the runner-up.
- C. NOTA disqualifies all listed candidates.
- D. NOTA converts India to recall elections.

Answer: A

Remedial explanation: PUCL (2013) concerns secrecy and choice, not automatic rejection of the field. Write the governing source, then the mechanism, and finally the limitation before choosing an option.

RM10. Which statement best repairs a recurring error about anti-defection interface?

- A. The Symbols Order and Tenth Schedule are the same proceeding.
- B. The Tenth Schedule disciplines legislators; it is not a general code for party membership or finance.
- C. Every internal party dispute is decided by the Speaker.
- D. A party whip can criminally punish a voter.

Answer: B

Remedial explanation: Party, legislature-party, symbol and defection questions remain distinct. Write the governing source, then the mechanism, and finally the limitation before choosing an option.

RM11. Which statement best repairs a recurring error about deregistration?

- A. The Supreme Court barred cancellation even for fraud.
- B. Recognition withdrawal and registration cancellation are identical.
- C. Indian National Congress v. Institute of Social Welfare (2002) limits ECI cancellation to narrow grounds such as fraud or loss of foundational allegiance.
- D. The ECI has an unlimited policy power to deregister inactive parties.

Answer: C

Remedial explanation: Registration power does not imply a general merits-based deregistration power. Write the governing source, then the mechanism, and finally the limitation before choosing an option.

RM12. Which statement best repairs a recurring error about regional parties and coalitions?

- A. Regional parties are constitutionally confined to State elections.
- B. National parties always favour autonomy.
- C. Coalitions are unconstitutional when no party has a majority.
- D. Regional parties can deepen federal representation while also increasing bargaining and coordination costs.

Answer: D

Remedial explanation: Effects depend on incentives, alliances and institutional context. Write the governing source, then the mechanism, and finally the limitation before choosing an option.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

DIRECT UPSC PYQ - 2022 GS-II Q13 - 15 marks - 250 words

Question (exact): "While the national political parties in India favour centralisation, the regional parties are in favour of State autonomy." Comment.

Demand decode: test the proposition, explain incentives and organisation, provide counter-evidence, and end with institutional safeguards rather than a partisan stereotype.

Model answer:

The proposition captures a recurring tendency, but not an immutable ideological divide. A national party that governs or seeks to govern the Union internalises the advantages of uniform programmes, centrally sponsored schemes, Union control over national institutions and a centralised high command. Regional parties, whose support is territorially concentrated, more often demand fiscal space, linguistic and cultural autonomy, a restrained Governor and greater consultation in Union law-making.

The coalition era of 1989-2014 strengthened this bargaining federalism: State parties used parliamentary leverage to obtain portfolios, grants and policy concessions. Their role also widened national representation by carrying sub-State and regional claims into the Union executive.

Yet position often matters more than label. A national party in State opposition may defend State autonomy; a regional party may centralise power within its own State or support centralising Union measures as a coalition partner. The 2014 and 2019 single-party majorities strengthened central coordination, while the coalition-supported government formed after the 2024 election again increased ally bargaining. Federalism is also constitutionally protected, not gifted

by parties: *S.R. Bommai* treats it as part of the basic structure, while the Finance Commission, GST Council, Inter-State Council and judicial review institutionalise negotiation.

Thus, the statement is a useful political tendency, not a law. Durable State autonomy requires rule-bound institutions, transparent fiscal federalism and internally federal party organisations.

Why this earns marks: It comments rather than merely agrees, explains causal mechanisms, uses chronology and constitutional institutions, and supplies counter-evidence.

How to improve this answer: Add one dated State-specific example only if it demonstrates reversal of party position; do not replace analysis with a list of regional parties.

Compression guidance: In 150 words retain the thesis, two causal reasons, one coalition-era counter, *Bommai*, and the institutional conclusion.

SUPPORTING UPSC PYQ - 2023 GS-II Q5 - 10 marks - 150 words - cross-owned with Parliament

Question (exact): “Discuss the role of Presiding Officers of state legislatures in maintaining order and impartiality in conducting legislative work and in facilitating best democratic practices.”

Model answer:

Presiding Officers convert partisan assemblies into rule-governed legislatures. They admit questions and motions, allocate speaking time, maintain order, interpret procedure, protect minority participation and authenticate legislative business. Impartial scheduling and reasoned rulings permit scrutiny rather than executive domination.

Their party background nevertheless creates pressure points. Defection petitions under the Tenth Schedule, recognition of legislative groups, suspensions, money-bill certification and committee referrals can affect government survival. *Kihoto Hollohan* subjected defection decisions to judicial review, while *Keisham Meghachandra* stressed timely disposal, illustrating why neutrality must be visible as well as claimed.

Best practice requires resignation from active party posts, published reasons, proportionate discipline, adequate Opposition time, live proceedings, strong committees and a binding time norm for defection cases. The office should be protected by convention and procedure so that the House, not the governing party, remains its institutional client.

Why this earns marks: It directly links functions, party pressure, case law and executable reforms within the word limit.

How to improve this answer: Name a particular State episode only when accurately recalled; the marks come from institutional analysis, not political allegation.

Compression guidance: Retain four functions, two pressure points, one case and three reforms.

ORIGINAL MAINS PRACTICE 1 - 15 marks - 250 words

Question: “India regulates political parties at their edges but not in their interior.” Critically examine.

Model answer:

India's legal framework controls a party's public interfaces more strongly than its internal constitution. Section 29A of the RPA regulates registration and constitutional allegiance. The Symbols Order regulates recognition and reserved symbols. The Tenth Schedule disciplines legislators, election law governs contributions and expenditure interfaces, and candidate-disclosure judgments protect voter information.

The organisational interior is thinner. There is no comprehensive statute prescribing transparent membership rolls, periodic leadership elections, candidate-selection procedures, audit independence or internal appeals. Section 29A registration is not equivalent to continuing democratic supervision. *Indian National Congress v Institute of Social Welfare* also denies the ECI a general power to deregister parties, except in narrow situations. As a result, dynastic succession, opaque nominations and high-command control can persist despite formally democratic party constitutions.

Over-regulation, however, could let the executive or ECI intrude into association under Article 19(1)(c), freeze diverse party forms and weaponise compliance against opposition. Reform should therefore focus on verifiable public-law minima: audited membership and finance disclosures, regular organisational elections, reasoned candidate selection, internal grievance mechanisms, proportionate sanctions and independent adjudication.

The objective is not State-managed parties but democratically accountable gatekeepers. Since parties select candidates and organise governments, constitutional democracy cannot remain agnostic to their internal concentration of power.

Why this earns marks: It proves the metaphor with statutes and a judgment, acknowledges associational freedom, and proposes calibrated regulation.

How to improve this answer: Distinguish ECI oversight from an independent adjudicatory mechanism; avoid saying the ECI can freely deregister non-compliant parties.

Compression guidance: Use a two-column mental frame: regulated edge / unregulated interior, followed by one liberty caveat and four safeguards.

ORIGINAL MAINS PRACTICE 2 - 10 marks - 150 words

Question: Distinguish registration, recognition and deregistration of political parties in India.

Model answer:

Registration under RPA Section 29A gives an association registered-party status after application to the ECI and an undertaking of allegiance to the Constitution and specified democratic principles. It does not by itself reserve a symbol or establish electoral performance.

Recognition is performance-based status under the Election Symbols Order, 1968, exercised under Article 324 read with Rules 5 and 10 of the Conduct of Elections Rules. A recognised national or State party receives a reserved symbol and related electoral facilities; criteria and status can change by ECI order.

Deregistration is not the mirror image of registration. In *Indian National Congress v Institute of Social Welfare* (2002), the Supreme Court held that the ECI lacks a general review or cancellation power. Cancellation is confined to narrow grounds such as fraud, foundational statutory non-compliance or a competent declaration of unlawfulness. Persistent inactivity may justify legislative reform, but not an invented administrative power.

Why this earns marks: It separates three frequently conflated concepts and anchors each in its correct legal source.

How to improve this answer: If space permits, add that derecognition affects symbols/facilities without necessarily cancelling Section 29A registration.

Compression guidance: Write three headed paragraphs: Section 29A; Symbols Order; narrow judicial exceptions.

ORIGINAL MAINS PRACTICE 3 - 10 marks - 150 words

Question: Explain how political parties perform both representative and governmental functions in a parliamentary democracy.

Model answer:

Political parties aggregate dispersed interests into programmes, recruit candidates, simplify electoral choice and mobilise citizens. These representative functions convert social cleavages and regional demands into negotiable legislative claims rather than extra-constitutional conflict.

After elections, the majority party or coalition forms the executive, coordinates ministers and legislators, frames budgets and legislation, and claims a mandate for policy. Opposition parties scrutinise expenditure, lead committees, expose alternatives and make peaceful alternation credible. Party whips supply stability, but excessive control can weaken deliberation and individual legislative judgment.

Parties also connect Union and State arenas. National organisations may coordinate nationwide policy; regional parties articulate territorial autonomy and improve federal bargaining. Yet opaque funding, criminalised selection and weak internal democracy can distort both representation and government.

Thus parties are not merely election machines. They are the operating institutions of parliamentary government, and their internal accountability affects the quality of public accountability.

Why this earns marks: The answer classifies functions, adds parliamentary and federal mechanisms, and ends with a democratic-quality link.

How to improve this answer: Use one precise example of Opposition committee scrutiny rather than naming many parties.

Compression guidance: Retain aggregation, recruitment, government formation, opposition scrutiny, federal linkage and one dysfunction.

ORIGINAL MAINS PRACTICE 4 - 15 marks - 250 words

Question: Examine the democratic deficit within Indian political parties and suggest constitutionally proportionate reforms.

Model answer:

Political parties are the principal gatekeepers of candidacy and government, yet their internal processes are often less democratic than the institutions they control. Leadership succession can be personalised; membership rolls and organisational elections may be unverifiable; candidate selection is centralised; finance and disciplinary decisions are opaque; and women and marginal groups remain under-represented in decision-making.

This deficit has external effects. Safe nominations can reward loyalty or winnability over integrity, centralised leadership weakens legislative deliberation, and opaque money can translate private access into public policy. Registration under Section 29A requires constitutional allegiance, but it does not provide a continuing internal-democracy code. Nor does the ECI possess a general deregistration power.

Reform must respect Article 19(1)(c) and political pluralism. Parliament should prescribe minimum, not uniform, standards: verified membership records; periodic and independently monitored organisational elections; published constitutions and candidate-selection criteria; audited accounts in open formats; internal appeals; gender-inclusive leadership targets; and graded sanctions tied to public benefits such as tax relief or recognition facilities. Disputes should receive independent, time-bound adjudication and judicial review.

The balance is between laissez-faire and bureaucratic capture. Public-law duties are justified because parties exercise public power, but ideology and lawful organisational diversity must remain free.

Why this earns marks: It links internal defects to constitutional consequences and designs proportionate rather than maximalist regulation.

How to improve this answer: Explain who verifies each disclosure; avoid a reform list with no enforcement architecture.

Compression guidance: Use defect -> democratic harm -> liberty caveat -> six minimum standards -> calibrated conclusion.

ORIGINAL MAINS PRACTICE 5 - 15 marks - 250 words

Question: Critically examine India's political-finance framework after the 2024 electoral-bonds judgment.

Model answer:

Political finance must enable participation without permitting concealed influence. The RPA allows contributions through Section 29B and requires reporting under Section 29C of contributions exceeding Rs 20,000, while tax, company and foreign-contribution laws create parallel controls. Electoral trusts and ordinary banking channels can provide traceable routes, but fragmented disclosure, third-party spending and enforcement delays remain concerns.

In *Association for Democratic Reforms v Union of India* (2024 INSC 113), a five-judge Bench struck down the Electoral Bond Scheme and enabling anonymity/unlimited-corporate-funding changes. It located political-donation information within voters' Article 19(1)(a) right to know, rejected blanket donor anonymity and ordered SBI-ECI disclosure. The judgment restored constitutional transparency and checked quid-pro-quo risks.

It did not create a complete finance code. Disclosure thresholds can fragment donations; audit quality varies; party and candidate accounts are not fully integrated; enforcement institutions face capacity and independence concerns; and lawful donor privacy or retaliation risks still require narrowly tailored protection.

Reform should require timely machine-readable donor reports, beneficial-ownership disclosure, independent audits, coordinated ECI-tax-company enforcement, transparent electoral-trust reporting, proportionate donation/spending rules and rapid adjudication. Any privacy exception should be evidence-based and reviewable.

The verdict removed an unconstitutional opacity mechanism; Parliament must now build a coherent transparency-and-fair-competition architecture.

Why this earns marks: It states surviving law, the exact constitutional holding, residual gaps and implementable reforms without treating the verdict as a complete code.

How to improve this answer: Never claim all anonymous funding ended; distinguish party receipts from candidate expenditure.

Compression guidance: Use law -> 2024 holding -> what remains unresolved -> five reforms -> verdict.

ORIGINAL MAINS PRACTICE 6 - 15 marks - 250 words

Question: Disclosure has exposed criminalisation in politics but has not displaced it. Analyse.

Model answer:

Judicial intervention has made criminal antecedents increasingly visible. *ADR* (2002) and *PUC* (2003) protected voter access to candidate information. *Public Interest Foundation* (2018) refused to judicially create a pre-conviction disqualification but required wider publicity. *Rambabu Singh Thakur* (2020) directed parties to publish pending cases and reasons for selecting such candidates, based on qualifications rather than mere winnability. *Lily Thomas* (2013) removed Section 8(4)'s special protection after conviction.

Yet disclosure does not alter selection incentives. Parties may prefer candidates with money, local networks or coercive influence; voters may discount cases viewed as political; trials are delayed; and publicity can become a formal checkbox. A blanket pre-conviction ban would also conflict with presumption of innocence and could invite strategic prosecutions.

The response should target both delay and party accountability: fast-track serious cases framed by courts sufficiently before elections; uniform, prominent and searchable disclosures; reasoned selection records; financial or electoral consequences for non-compliance; witness protection; and clean-candidate incentives within parties. Disqualification should remain conviction-linked unless Parliament enacts a narrowly defined, safeguarded rule for grave offences.

Transparency is necessary for informed choice, but deterrence requires timely adjudication and changed party incentives.

Why this earns marks: The answer gives the full judgment chain, identifies causal incentives, protects due process and proposes safeguards.

How to improve this answer: State that a stay of conviction may affect disqualification; suspension of sentence alone is not the same.

Compression guidance: Four cases in one line, three persistence causes, due-process caveat and four remedies.

ORIGINAL MAINS PRACTICE 7 - 10 marks - 150 words

Question: Why are India's controls over political parties described as fragmented? Suggest an institutional design response.

Model answer:

Party regulation is distributed across the RPA, Symbols Order, Conduct of Elections Rules, Income-tax Act, Companies Act, FCRA, Tenth Schedule and judicial directions. Different bodies supervise different fragments: the ECI handles registration, recognition and disclosures; tax and corporate authorities inspect financial compliance; courts enforce voter information and constitutional limits; Presiding Officers decide defection initially.

Fragmentation creates gaps between party receipts and candidate spending, delayed data matching, weak audit comparability and uncertain sanctions. It also encourages forum-shifting and compliance without substantive accountability.

A response should not make one body omnipotent. Parliament can create interoperable disclosure standards, a common machine-readable portal, risk-based independent audits, statutory information-sharing, time-bound penalties and an appellate forum insulated from government and party control. The ECI should retain electoral functions while specialised regulators enforce tax, company and foreign-source rules.

Why this earns marks: It identifies sources, institutions, concrete coordination failures and a checks-and-balances solution.

How to improve this answer: Add one example of a mismatched data set, not a generic call for “strong ECI powers.”

Compression guidance: Sources -> coordination gaps -> shared data/audit/adjudication, while preserving institutional specialisation.

ORIGINAL MAINS PRACTICE 8 - 15 marks - 250 words

Question: Assess the contribution of regional parties to coalition governance and federalism in India.

Model answer:

Regional parties territorialise representation. They place language, identity, uneven development and State-specific fiscal claims on the national agenda. During the coalition era from 1989 to 2014, their parliamentary leverage widened executive participation, moderated unilateral central policy and converted Centre-State conflict into bargaining within government. They also made alternation possible beyond a single national pole.

Their contribution is not automatically federal or democratic. Coalition bargaining can become portfolio or grant particularism; small allies may exercise influence disproportionate to votes; regional parties may centralise power within their States; and opportunistic alliances can blur accountability. Conversely, national parties sometimes champion State autonomy when out of power, showing that institutional position matters more than party label.

The 2014 and 2019 Union majorities reduced coalition dependence but did not eliminate strong State-party competition. The coalition-supported government after the 2024 election again increased the relevance of allies. A durable federal role requires transparent coalition agreements, regular intergovernmental forums, predictable fiscal transfers, parliamentary scrutiny of bargains and internal democracy within regional parties.

Regional parties have therefore deepened India's representative federalism, but their bargaining must be constitutionalised through institutions rather than depend on electoral arithmetic alone.

Why this earns marks: It combines chronology, mechanisms, counter-arguments, current phase control and reforms.

How to improve this answer: Distinguish territorial representation from every instance of transactional coalition bargaining.

Compression guidance: Use contribution / limitations / post-2014 transition / institutional conclusion.